Nikolytics Decision Log,

Strategy Sessions of 2026-07-04

This log extends the Decision Log in `business-context.md` (last updated 2026-07-03). It records what Nikola decided in the 2026-07-04 sessions. The operating manual and founder appendix will be drafted from these decisions plus the approved working documents.

Style rules in force for all documents: plain and direct, no book-style theatrics, and no em dashes anywhere (Nikola, 2026-07-04).

Decisions

1. **Delivery capacity, asserted by Nikola.** Capacity and people exist; not a blocker. Track record: ~5 platforms built, largely single-handedly. Operating rule adopted: **internal ship target ~2 weeks, promised delivery 30 days.** The buffer absorbs client feedback rounds and guarantees clients experience "early," never "late." A 3-person team on one build is considered more than sufficient.
2. **The 90-day calendar (channel-plan §8) is discarded.** Its premise, a large untouched warm list, is wrong: Nikola has already asked his warm circle for everything they have. The channel plan will be rebuilt founder-led: LinkedIn rebuild, outreach to new funded founders, content as the urgent priority, the Mark partnership (below), Reddit as a gated experiment.
3. **Landing page: HTML discarded entirely** (wrong direction and concept). `landing-copy.md` v1 is raw material only, not approved. Final website copy will be human-written; the site will be deliberately designed with the web team. The messaging session produces a brief for the web team, not finished copy.
4. **Planning assumptions stand as labeled placeholders** (warm CAC $5k, flagship fulfillment $35k all-in, Blueprint fulfillment $12k, conversion targets). Zero empirical numbers exist yet; these are the best available, and every document must mark them as assumptions until replaced by measured data.
5. **Deliverable = two Markdown documents in this repo**, which Nikola downloads, reviews, and edits first:
   - The shareable **operating manual**: for team, partners, lead-sourcing agents, marketing agencies, the website team.
   - The **founder appendix**: internal numbers only: cash position, margins, CAC ceilings, equity, NDA notes, negotiation internals.
6. **Offer name: "Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint" confirmed** as the product name and current control frame (research amendment 3, "Board-Proof" first, declined as the lead; it may enter the wrapper rotation later). New messaging direction to develop: **full pressure transfer** (worry-free, fully outsourced, "you hand me the money and I take 100% of the pressure") as the emotional lead, always backed by the mechanism proof

(the contractual terms), never as a bare claim. Research amendments **1 (certainty-led positioning), 2 (ban "MVP" from all copy), 4 (first 100 conversations double as the demand-validation study), and 5 (arm the Cheap Build Teardown with research citations) are accepted.**

7. **Wrapper candidate rejected: "The One-Hour-a-Day Platform Build."** Ambiguous: it can read as the team working one hour a day rather than the client spending one hour a day. The underlying fact (client effort under one hour a day) stays as a stack item and proof point, always phrased from the client's side ("your time commitment: under an hour a day").
8. **Referral partner: Mark** (fundraising agent; works with founders raising capital and with investors; highly trusted; terms will be put in writing). Structure agreed:
   - **$2,500 when a referred Blueprint collects; $22,500 more when the referred build's signing payment collects** ($25,000 total, ≈ 8.6:1 LTGP:CAC, inside the $48k paid-CAC governor).
   - Qualified referral, defined in writing: funded US founder, seed to Series B, platform need, delivered as a 3-way introduction.
   - Fees paid on collected cash only, never on signatures.
   - Mandatory disclosure to the referred founder that a referral arrangement exists.
   - Performance kicker possible later (toward the $48k ceiling after repeated collected builds); paid forever, never capped.
   - Mark's pre-existing ~20% arrangement: details left with Nikola; for Nikolytics builds the structure above supersedes it, to be confirmed in the written terms.
9. **Steering metric: close, deliver, and document the first client through the new system.** A 12-month revenue target is deliberately deferred; logged as a decision, no longer an open question.
10. **Cash: late-July collections (~$140k) are hoped for, not certain** (funded-project risk). The bootstrapped rule is reaffirmed as financial principle #1: spend only collected cash. Possible upside: Shane payments if Paragons Performance and the foundation side accelerate.
11. **Client-origin facts, corrected by Nikola.** Shane found Nikola on an automation subreddit where Nikola was asking for a mentor; Shane asked to become his client. Nikola's read, accepted into the log: this was extreme luck, not a repeatable mechanism, and it happened in an automation context, not platforms. Corrected conclusion: **Nikolytics has no proven repeatable acquisition channel yet.** This raises the weight of the demand-validation study (amendment 4) and of building the first repeatable system deliberately. Sport Endorse and The Players Impact came through the Paragons build. Reddit stays a gated experiment, only where genuinely high-ticket buyers demonstrably sit.
12. **Foundations: formally parked, rationale captured.** Foundations need platforms and are run by wealthy people who would use the saved time to help their cause, but they are problem-unaware on the awareness ladder, which makes them an education-led market. Revisit trigger: an established social-media presence (Instagram named) capable of educating that audience. Until then: no investment.
13. **Paragons proof logged (first real quantified outcome).** American Paragons is launched and live: ~1,000 Team USA / Olympic athletes on the platform (~1/3 of USA's athletes, Nikola's estimate) plus hundreds of supporters; Shane is actively driving usage. Paragons Performance: built, awaiting marketing funding. **Publish gates before any public use:** Shane's written permission per the co-content agreement; the athlete figure verified and precisely phrased; "Team USA" wording checked (USOPC-protected term; describe facts, imply no endorsement). Nikola acknowledges the USOPC caution.

14. **INTIIMI disclosure:** Nikola will discuss scope with the founder directly. Until resolved, the NDA rule is unchanged: never referenced publicly.
15. **LinkedIn baseline: the account has been untouched since college.** The profile rebuild is a named workstream and precedes any outreach volume. Outreach volumes will be sized to LinkedIn's real mechanics for a dormant account (connection-request caps, gradual warmup), not to the book's 100-per-day default, which assumed an existing warm list across many channels.
16. **Content: a fully dedicated session is decided.** Agenda set by Nikola: (1) who am I, (2) what am I talking about, (3) what I want my avatar to see, (4) open exploration beyond those. Purpose: define the content identity before the first post and produce content pillars, the LinkedIn profile copy inputs, the first two weeks of concrete posts, and a low-friction publishing ritual. Context noted: starting is the hard part; the session exists to remove the blank-page problem.
17. **Founder time budget: 3 hours per day total for outreach plus content**, Nikola's stated priority for the coming days. All quotas size to this number, not to the old plan's 5+ hours.
18. **Evergreen Codebase Plan confirmed unchanged after challenge.** Nikola questioned whether the included 12 months should become 6 included + 6 paid, to start recurring revenue earlier. Decision: keep 12 months included, 24 on Full-Send. Reasons: the bonus kills the legacy-system objection and powers the $85k prepay incentive (day-0 cash is the binding constraint); shrinking it would weaken the $250k close for small maintenance fees and contradict the no-lock-in positioning; the applicable book rule is "extend, don't eat, the term." Recurring revenue routes to the existing layer: the Product Engine (primary), the Extended Shield, and the year-two Evergreen renewal (month-10 conversation, prepay incentivized, 4-week billing). The Engine's hire gate may be revisited once the first build lands.
19. **Voice decision: the infomercial tone does not transfer; the candor does.** The Nykolator lead magnet and the old automation website are retired (Nikola). The new voice on all flagship surfaces (website, offer documents, outreach): deadpan candor; blunt, verifiable specifics; dry wit allowed sparingly and never in the hero, never near the price, never near the guarantee; no parody register, no joke statistics, no fake-disclaimer bits. Rationale: parody anchors to the cheap tier, and irony fails the skim-and-forward test (artifacts travel to boards and technical advisors). Personal LinkedIn content may carry more personality. Noted for reuse: the Nykolator's interactive-diagnostic mechanic (answer questions, get calculated results by email) is structurally the planned Real-Cost Build Estimator; the mechanic transfers, the register does not.
20. **Website strategy: the site itself is proof asset #1** (Nikola's direction, sharpened together). Rationale: with zero public case studies, the site is the only build a prospect can inspect without permission; visual excellence is evidence, not decoration. Conditions that make the visuals read as engineering proof: (a) working software embedded in the site (the Real-Cost Build Estimator as a real tool); (b) live real data on the page (fill-level counter, Blueprint seats, next cohort date); (c) performance as a feature (instant loads, flawless mobile); (d) built on the same design system sold to clients as Bonus 1, and stated as such; (e) craft accelerates the reading path to the copy and the mechanisms, never buries them (no loading theater, no scroll-jacking; price and guarantee never under animation). Additional direction: document the building of the new site as the first public Build Diary (self-client, no NDA gates; produces pre-outreach content and proves the sprint process publicly). Sequencing guard: a small immaculate v1 (hero, mechanisms, Teardown booking, live counters) ships before outreach; estimator and diary sections are phase two.

Session order from here

1. **Content identity and positioning session** (Nikola's four agenda items; feeds the LinkedIn profile rebuild).
2. **First-client pipeline session:** LinkedIn profile rebuild plan, outreach mechanics and honest volumes, Mark activation, and the close path (Teardown to Blueprint to Sprint, including the decoy presentation, the 7-day Debrief rule, and the payment-terms ladder).
3. **Post-close machinery session:** the money model's unreviewed remainder (Traction Block, Product Engine, micro-plays, caps), which activates on later gates.
4. **Messaging and web team brief session.**
5. **Open-items sweep plus canonical facts sheet.**
6. **Draft both documents, Nikola review, finalize.**

Recommendation standing unless vetoed: the operating manual leads with the first-client pipeline; the post-close machinery is documented as designed but staged behind its quarter gates.